

The three conversations

Every hard conversation is three at once: what happened, how it feels, and what it says about you. Sort them out on paper before you have them out loud.

FOR A CONVERSATION · STONE, PATTON AND HEEN, 1999 · TAKES HALF AN HOUR

HOW TO RUN IT

1. Write your story of what happened. Then write theirs, as they would tell it to a friend. Both are true to the person telling them.
2. Separate intent from impact. What you think they meant is a guess; what it did to you is a fact. Write both, and notice you have only guessed at their intent.
3. Map contributions instead of blame. What did each of you do that helped this happen? Yours goes on the page too, or the conversation is an accusation.
4. Name the feelings, yours and theirs as you'd guess them. Unnamed feelings leak into tone.
5. Ask the identity question: what does this threaten about how I see myself? Competent, fair, a good friend? That is usually why it is hard.
6. Decide your purpose: to learn their story, to say yours, to solve something together. Then write the opening in the third story, how a neutral observer would describe the situation, and start there.

Where it falls down. Going in to prove your story is the true one, which is the one thing the conversation cannot do.

WITH A PEN

My story of what happened

Their story, as they'd tell a friend

What I think they meant

A guess

What it did to me

A fact

What each of us contributed

Mine goes here too

Feelings, mine and theirs

What this threatens about how I see myself

My purpose, and the opening in the third story

How a neutral observer would describe it
